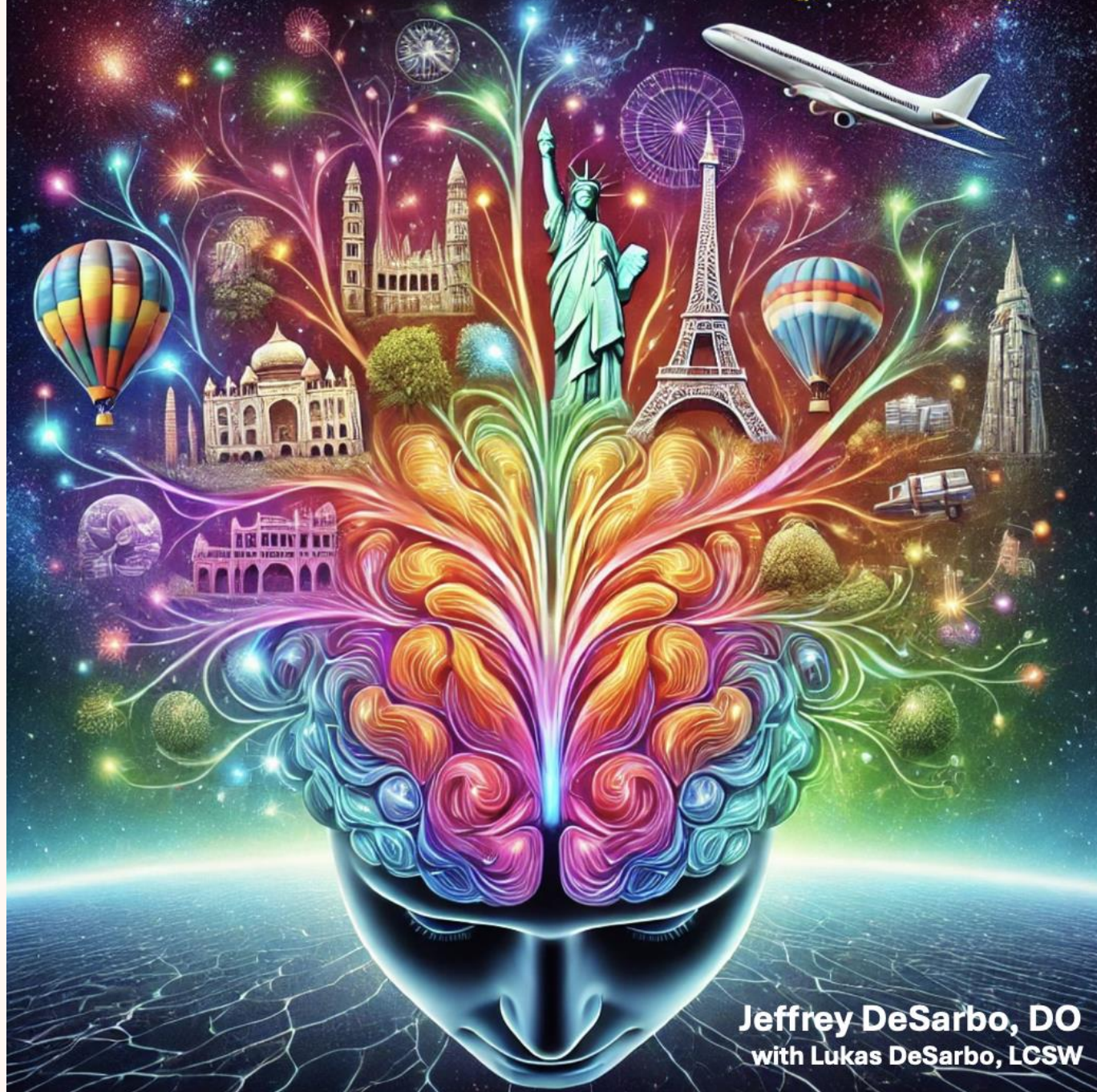


The Bucket List Brain Starter Kit

A Neuroscience-Based Guide To Living More Fully



Jeffrey DeSarbo, DO
with Lukas DeSarbo, LCSW

The Bucket List Brain Starter Kit

A Neuroscience-Based Guide to Living More Fully

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with Lukas DeSarbo, LCSW

Authors of:

The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most From Your Brain and Life

The Neuroscience of a Bucket List Workbook: The Companion Guide to Transform Your Life
and *The Eating Disorder Supplement to The Neuroscience of a Bucket List*



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Disclaimer

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Original concepts, text content, and final designs of all art, graphics, and content by Dr. Jeffrey DeSarbo.

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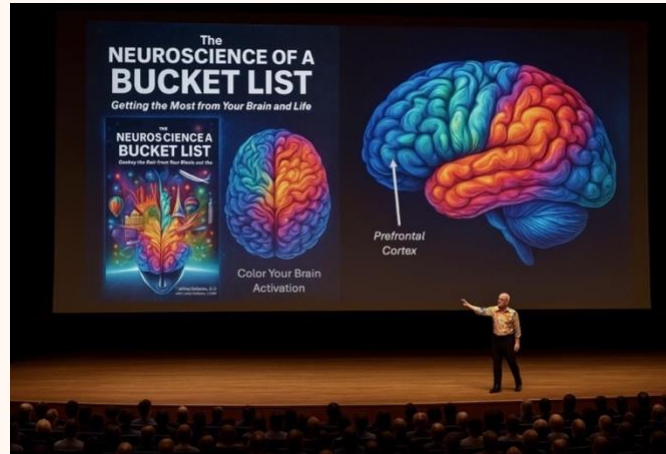
A Welcome Message

Congratulations on taking your first step toward living more intentionally and joyfully. I'm Dr. Jeffrey R. DeSarbo — a neuropsychiatrist and lifelong adventurer who believes your brain is wired for purpose and you are entitled to peace and happiness. This is **YOUR** “Starter Kit.”

It's your introduction to how the simple act of creating a bucket list can activate powerful neural systems that promote motivation, excitement, mental well-being, and gratitude in your life. This Starter Kit was designed to be different from a traditional book. Rather than teaching concepts found in the main text, it was created to help you begin taking action immediately through exercises, prompts, neuroscience, and practical tools designed to help your brain reconnect with curiosity, motivation, and meaningful experiences.

After decades of study and practice in neuropsychiatry, and nearly as much time intentionally living with a bucket list approach in life, I was inspired to finally write *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most From Your Brain and Life* and the companion workbook to help others share the journey that so many people have benefitted from. In the pages ahead, we will help you start your journey today. However, we recommend you read the full framework of this system in the main title, *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life*, as that will help you better understand and put the research format into practice, step by step. This Starter Kit is offered as a guide to help you conceptualize some thoughts and how to record and format them as you go through your bucket list planning and your bucket list life. For now, take a deep breath, grab a pen, and let's have fun getting started on re-training your brain for a life that feels more alive and hopeful.

Additionally, you are invited to visit our website **BucketListDoctor.com** for more information, additional related and important articles, ideas, and inspiration.



A Basic Understanding Before You Start

Most people think a bucket list is just a set of things to do before you die: travel the world, skydive, write a book, or learn to play the guitar. But this process is more than a checklist and it's timeless. It's not just for the wealthy or for retirement. It's an approach for those at any age regardless of means or status.

Understanding how your brain works with a bucket list reveals its transformational power. It's not just what you accomplish; it's what happens as you imagine, plan, and act. This simple kit lets you *learn* the science and try it yourself. It's intended to get the wheels turning in your head. And while you begin to get a basic grasp of neuroscience, your list deepens and becomes a living framework that boosts motivation, purpose, and gratitude with surprisingly little effort.



When you write a goal, your brain's reward system releases dopamine, the neurotransmitter of anticipation and drive. Planning future experiences begins reshaping your mood and motivation networks. That's why just envisioning a mountain hike can lift your spirits now, before you go. This isn't wishful thinking; it's chemistry. At the same time, serotonin increases as you picture meaningful outcomes, and oxytocin, the "connection" hormone, rises when you add social goals like volunteering, reconnecting, or mentoring.

Sarah, a 42-year-old teacher, once felt "stuck in routine." She began with three bucket list categories singled out in *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List* as necessary: travel, giving back, and mindfulness. Her first entry was simple: "Volunteer at a local animal shelter." In two weeks, she fed kittens and helped families adopt pets. Behind the scenes, her brain strengthened the salience network, which finds what truly matters. Her sense of purpose wasn't imagined; it was neural. The more she engaged, the more her planning center synced with reward circuits, motivating more effort. Soon, she added "take a weekend photography trip," reawakening her curiosity. That blend of giving and discovery brought new energy, gratitude, and the biological antidote to burnout. This is a typical scenario of how it all begins and then grow



Each bucket list entry activates brain regions that help turn dreams into action. The Default Mode Network helps you visualize and define who you want to be. The Salience Network filters your dreams, showing which feel meaningful now. The Central Executive Network turns those into real plans. Switching between imagining, choosing, and acting exercises brain pathways that drive motivation, focus, and follow-through. Bucket listing is mental cross-training, strengthening networks for engagement and purpose.

Our main title book we explain how this process boosts neuroplasticity and the brain's ability to form new connections. It supports neurogenesis, the growth of new neurons in regions like the hippocampus, which regulates learning and memory. Each time you try something new, even a small recipe or event, your brain adapts, expands, and grows more resilient. Novelty, meaning, and emotional engagement spur brain growth. A well-built bucket list supplies all three.

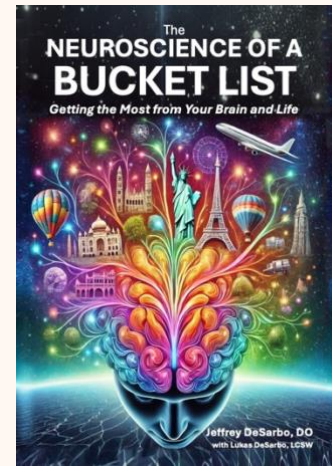
For youth, this supports the development of the brain by fostering curiosity, confidence, and emotional regulation. For adults, it strengthens mental health by countering stagnation and negative thought loops. For older adults, it helps maintain flexibility and protect against decline by keeping the brain stimulated. Think of it as mental fitness, not from puzzles, but from real, meaningful experiences your brain enjoys.

Tom, 68 and retired, first thought bucket listing sounded frivolous. After reading *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List*, he began a "Giving Back" category and started mentoring first-generation college students. In six months, he felt more motivated, slept better, and his wife said he seemed "lighter." His actions recalibrated his dopamine-serotonin balance, reducing anxiety and elevating his mood. Instead of just changing his routine, he rewired his brain, all at no financial expense.



While this Starter Kit begins to organize your goals, its true aim is to introduce you to the concepts of how you can reorganize your brain and how you can enhance your approach in life. You'll see how each bucket list entry builds motivation and gratitude

In addition to giving detailed information about building your personalized bucket list system, *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life* explains the brain science, covering neurotransmitters, neurohormones, neuroplasticity, and the main brain networks for focus and joy. It describes how every step affects these brain systems and improves cognitive health. The *Workbook* adds numerous guided templates and exercises. Together, they provide a blueprint for achieving your dreams and optimizing your brain.



The neuroscience of bucket listing shows this truth: living with meaningful goals fills life with gratitude, connection, and vitality. You don't have to force deep, meaningful joy; your brain is ready to create it once you begin.

The Challenge of Getting Started

Many people assume that if something feels meaningful enough, motivation should naturally follow. Unfortunately, the brain rarely works that way. One of the most misunderstood aspects of human motivation is that action often precedes motivation rather than follows it. People frequently wait to feel inspired, energized, confident, or “ready” before beginning, while the brain itself waits for evidence that an activity is worth investing energy in. From a neuroscience perspective, motivation is not simply a personality trait or a fixed characteristic; it is an active biological process involving networks responsible for reward prediction, salience detection, decision-making, and energy conservation. When a goal feels too large, too uncertain, too unfamiliar, or too disconnected from immediate reward, the brain naturally becomes hesitant. The result is often procrastination that feels confusing because, intellectually, the person still wants the change.

Adding to this challenge is the reality that many adult brains become highly optimized for efficiency and routine. Over time, repeated behaviors strengthen familiar neural pathways, while novelty, exploration, and uncertainty become more effortful. This creates a frustrating cycle: the person wants something different, but their brain has become increasingly specialized in maintaining what is already known. The initial spark people are searching for is often not

missing; it is simply buried beneath habit loops, emotional exhaustion, fear of failure, perfectionism, decision overload, or years spent prioritizing responsibilities over curiosity. This is why building a bucket list is rarely about waiting for a sudden surge of inspiration. More often,



it is about creating enough small actions to convince your brain that movement itself is safe, rewarding, and worth repeating.

The encouraging news is that motivation is often far more trainable than most people realize. If the brain learns through repetition, prediction, and reward, then the solution is not to wait for a dramatic burst of inspiration; it is to create conditions that allow motivation to gradually emerge. Sometimes, this means thinking smaller, lowering the pressure, and focusing less on creating a perfect bucket list and more on simply creating movement. The goal is not to plan your entire future today. The goal is to remind your brain how to become curious again. Small actions matter because each one sends biological signals to the brain that exploration, novelty, learning, and change are still relevant. In many ways, motivation behaves much like a muscle: the more consistently it is exercised, the easier it becomes to activate.

This Starter Kit was intentionally designed with this understanding in mind. Rather than asking you to immediately create an extraordinary life plan, it is meant to function as a gentle neurological warm-up. The exercises ahead are designed to reduce decision overload, stimulate curiosity, create small experiences of success, and help reconnect you with parts of yourself that may have become buried beneath routine and responsibility. Some exercises may feel easy. Some may feel uncomfortable. Both are normal. You do not need to complete everything perfectly or all at once. You simply need to begin: to lay the first brick that strengthens your fulfillment foundation.

"The secret of getting ahead is getting started."

— Mark Twain

The InPig Principle: What A Bucket List Is Truly About

Many people hear the words “bucket list” and immediately imagine luxury vacations, climbing mountains, buying exotic cars, or spending excessive amounts of money. While these experiences certainly can belong on someone’s list, they completely miss what a bucket list is truly designed to accomplish. A meaningful bucket list is not simply a collection of expensive, wild, or daring experiences to check off before you die, as the popular 2007 movie *The Bucket List* starring Jack Nicholson and Morgan Freeman perpetuated. Rather, it is a neuropsychological system designed to create direction, motivation, purpose, and forward movement throughout life, encouraging brain health and mental well-being. We prefer to conceptualize bucket lists using what we call the ***InPig Principle***: **Intrinsic, Novelty, Purpose, Intentional, and Gratitude**.

To begin, a meaningful bucket lists should be *intrinsic*, meaning they reflect what genuinely matters to *you* rather than what impresses others, appears socially desirable, or simply reflects what everyone



else seems to be doing or wants you to do for or with them. This distinction is important because many people spend enormous portions of their lives pursuing goals they believe they *should* want rather than goals they actually want. Intrinsic goals tend to create stronger motivation because they align with personal values, interests, identity, curiosity, and a sense of meaning. They are the goals you would still pursue even if nobody else ever knew you accomplished them. In many ways, intrinsic motivation serves as the foundation for everything else, because goals that are not personally meaningful are often the first to be abandoned when life becomes busy, stressful, or difficult.

Novelty with a bucket list means doing new things, exploring unfamiliar experiences, learning new skills, exposing yourself to different environments, and sometimes stepping outside of your comfort zone. Novel experiences stimulate learning, adaptation, flexibility, and neuroplasticity while helping prevent our world from gradually becoming smaller. Creating variety across categories becomes important because repeatedly experiencing novelty appears to provide some of the strongest signals that the brain needs to continue adapting rather than simply becoming increasingly efficient, rigid, and routine-driven.

From a neuroscience perspective, novelty matters because the brain changes in response to new challenges and demands. New experiences require the brain to form new associations, recruit different networks, strengthen connections between regions, and continually update predictions about the world around us.

Over time, lives dominated by repetition and rigid routines may unintentionally create environments where the brain receives fewer signals that growth and adaptation are still needed. While novelty alone is certainly not a magic cure for aging, accumulating evidence suggests that lifelong learning, exploration, cognitive challenge, social engagement, and exposure to new experiences may help strengthen cognitive reserve and potentially reduce vulnerability to premature cognitive aging and decline. In many ways, novelty serves as a biological reminder to the brain that life is still changing and that it should continue changing with it.

Purpose gives the brain something meaningful to anticipate, pursue, and organize around rather than simply existing on autopilot.

Humans are naturally future-oriented organisms, and many brain systems involved in motivation, attention, decision-making, and emotional regulation function best when directed toward goals that feel personally meaningful. Purpose creates psychological momentum because it gives experiences context and provides a reason to tolerate discomfort, uncertainty, setbacks, and effort.

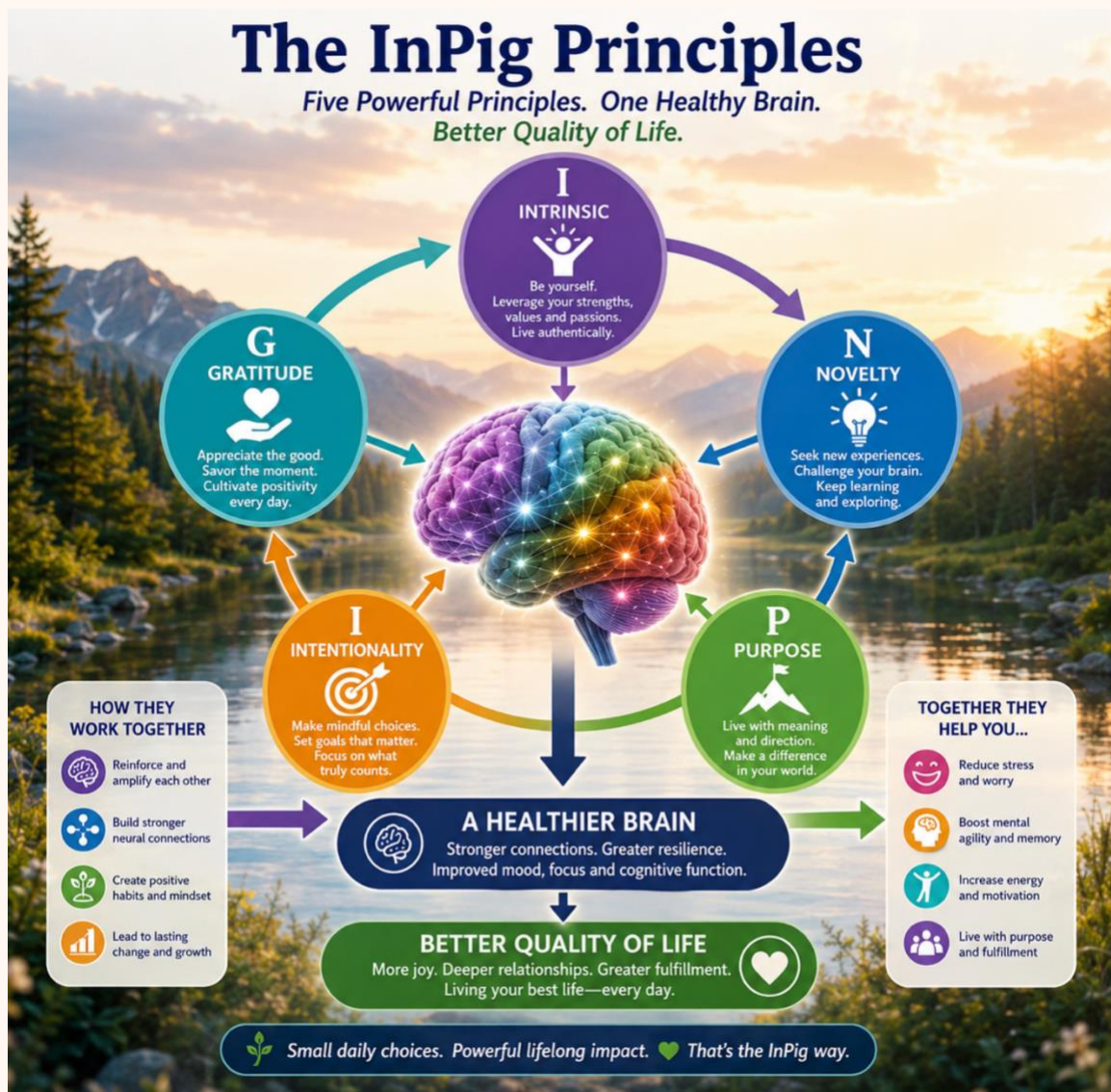


Without purpose, life can gradually become dominated by routine, obligation, and repetition. Purpose does not necessarily mean discovering one grand mission or changing the world; it may be as simple as planning experiences with family, learning a skill, creating something meaningful, helping others, or giving yourself reasons to remain curious about the future. In many ways, purpose acts like a psychological compass, helping direct attention toward where you want to go rather than simply reacting to where life pushes you.

The *intentional* selection of your bucket list categories and goals is a key component, because fulfilling lives rarely happen by accident. We spend enormous portions of our lives doing things we feel we have to do: work responsibilities, obligations, schedules, expectations, and activities driven by the needs and desires of others. Intentionality means consciously deciding what *you*

choose to pursue. It transforms vague wishes into actions, plans, habits, and decisions that create movement while restoring something many people gradually lose over time: a greater sense of control and ownership over their own lives.

Finally, all of this should strengthen life's *gratitude*, because some of the most important bucket-list experiences are not necessarily extraordinary moments, but rather learning to fully experience and appreciate ordinary ones. Gratitude also encourages something equally important: reflection. As we move forward through time, bucket lists, journals, photographs, notes, souvenirs, stories, and memories allow us to periodically look back and recognize how much life we have actually lived. Keeping records of experiences, whether through journaling,



photos, digital albums, videos, scrapbooks, or simple written notes, creates something powerful: evidence of movement. Evidence that time was not simply spent, but experienced.

The pig chasing the carrot serves as a useful metaphor because our brains naturally respond to movement toward meaningful rewards. A bucket list acts much like that carrot; not because
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happiness permanently exists at the finish line, but because having something meaningful ahead of us changes how we experience the journey itself. Goals, plans, dreams, and future experiences create anticipation, engagement, learning, and motivation.

Ultimately, the goal is not to build a bucket list that impresses other people. The goal is to create categories, goals, experiences, and dreams that keep your mind engaged, your world expanding, and your brain reminded that life is still unfolding. Sometimes that carrot may be traveling across the world. Sometimes it may simply be learning chess, planting a garden, watching fireflies with your grandchildren, volunteering, taking a dance class, or finally reading the books that have been collecting dust on your shelf. The size of the carrot matters far less than continuing to move toward it.

The scientific foundations behind the InPig Principle, and the neuroscience explaining why these experiences influence motivation, neuroplasticity, emotional health, cognitive resilience, and overall brain functioning, are explored in significantly greater detail throughout the main original book. Think of this Starter Kit as the introduction; the deeper explanation of *why* these principles work comes next.

Your Bucket List Style and the BRAIN Framework

Your bucket list is not simply a collection of random experiences; it often reflects how your brain naturally seeks meaning, reward, connection, growth, and fulfillment. One of the mistakes many people make when beginning is assuming there is a “correct” type of bucket list. Some people immediately imagine skydiving and adventure travel, while others become excited about family experiences, creative projects, learning opportunities, or simply finding more peace in everyday life. The reality is that healthy, fulfilling bucket lists come in many forms because healthy, fulfilling brains are built differently. In my work and writing, We often describe these differences through what we call the **BRAIN** framework: a simplified way to understand the major styles people tend to use to pursue meaningful experiences. Here we introduce a streamlined version of the framework to help you begin exploring where your motivations may naturally fit.



As you move through the exercises ahead, remember that most people are not exclusively one style but rather have a hierarchy of styles. You may discover that some goals reflect Balance and mindfulness while others reflect adventure, learning, relationships, or novelty. You may also notice areas that feel underdeveloped; parts of yourself that have quietly received less attention over time. This is not meant to place you into a category or label your personality. Instead, think of it as a starting map. The goal is not simply to create more experiences, but to create experiences that align with the unique ways your brain naturally finds purpose, motivation, curiosity, and meaning.

Beginning the Kickstart Worksheets

Before jumping into the worksheets ahead, it is important to understand something: there is no right or wrong way to complete them. You are not being graded. You are not expected to create the perfect bucket list, discover your life purpose overnight, or suddenly become highly motivated after filling out a few pages. These exercises were intentionally designed to do something much simpler: to help your brain begin moving again.

Many people make the mistake of believing that motivation comes first and that action follows. In reality, the opposite is often true. Small actions frequently create motivation rather than waiting for motivation to magically appear. Each worksheet ahead was designed with this principle in mind. Some exercises are meant to stimulate curiosity. Others help organize thoughts, reconnect with forgotten interests, identify blind spots, or create small experiences of success. Think of these exercises less like assignments and more like neurological warmups. The goal is not perfection. The goal is movement.

The worksheets ahead were also intentionally organized in a specific sequence. Rather than immediately asking you to build a complete bucket list, they are designed to gradually move your brain through the process of exploration, reflection, organization, and action. Each worksheet serves a different purpose and targets slightly different ways that your brain generates motivation, meaning, curiosity, and change.

Before beginning, take a moment to understand what each worksheet is trying to accomplish and how the exercise may help you. Remember, the goal is not to complete these perfectly. The goal is simply to begin.

Kickstart Worksheet #1: The Five Minute Brain Dump

Many people assume they do not have bucket list ideas when, in reality, they often have too many ideas buried beneath routine, responsibilities, and everyday distractions. This exercise is designed to bypass perfectionism and overthinking by allowing your brain to simply generate possibilities without judgment. Imagine someone sitting down believing they have “nothing interesting” to write, only to discover after five minutes that they filled an entire page with forgotten dreams, postponed experiences, and ideas they had not considered in years. The goal is not organization—it is simply opening the door.

Kickstart Worksheet #2: The “Someday” Exercise

Many goals fail because they remain trapped in vague language like “one day” or “eventually.” This worksheet helps move those thoughts from abstract ideas into conscious awareness. Imagine someone who has said for twenty years that they would “learn guitar someday” finally writing those words down and realizing that perhaps the goal was never impossible; it simply never had a place to live outside their thoughts. The goal of this exercise is not commitment. It is visibility.

Kickstart Worksheet #3: Future Self Exercise

Humans naturally prioritize immediate demands while underestimating how quickly years pass. This exercise helps shift perspective by asking you to temporarily step outside your current stressors and imagine the person you are becoming. Picture yourself ten years older looking back, not asking whether you answered enough emails or completed enough chores, but asking whether you spent enough time building a life you actually wanted to live. This exercise helps the brain connect present actions with future meaning.

Kickstart Worksheet #4: Finding Your Missing Categories

Sometimes the problem is not that life is empty; it is that life becomes unbalanced. A person may have achievement but little fun. Relationships but little adventure. Productivity but very little novelty. Imagine someone realizing they have spent years building a successful career while discovering that creativity, playfulness, or connection quietly disappeared along the way. This worksheet helps identify areas of life that may deserve more attention moving forward.

Kickstart Worksheet #5: Build Your First Micro Goal

Large goals often fail because the brain perceives them as expensive, uncertain, or overwhelming. This worksheet intentionally focuses on making goals smaller because action itself frequently creates motivation. Imagine someone whose bucket list item says “travel internationally” but whose first micro-goal becomes simply applying for a passport or researching flights. The purpose of this exercise is to teach your brain that movement matters more than speed.

Kickstart Worksheet #6: Your First Bucket List Page

Many people become overwhelmed trying to create enormous bucket lists immediately. This worksheet intentionally asks for only a few items because starting small creates momentum. Imagine someone who believed they needed one hundred goals before beginning but instead discovers that five meaningful experiences are enough to create excitement and direction. The goal here is not quantity but in creating your first true starting point.

Worksheet #7: Building Your Bucket List Categories

Before building goals, experiences, or adventures, it helps to understand what areas of life actually matter to you. This worksheet focuses less on creating activities and more on creating a structure that reflects your values, interests, and priorities. Imagine someone realizing that nearly every goal they initially considered involved work or achievement, only to discover through this exercise that connection, mindfulness, or giving back had quietly disappeared from their life. Sometimes building a meaningful bucket list begins not with asking what you want to do, but by asking what parts of life deserve more space.

Kickstart Your Life Now

Although these worksheets are designed to help you uncover your own authentic, intrinsic bucket list, many people find that completing them with a spouse, partner, family member, or close friend makes the experience even more meaningful. Sharing



your answers often sparks conversations that might never have happened otherwise: discussions about dreams, values, fears, interests, and life experiences that reveal new sides of people you thought you already knew well.

You may discover that your partner has always wanted to learn a musical instrument, that your parent dreams of visiting a place they have never mentioned, or that your friend has aspirations hidden beneath years of routine. Working through the exercises together can also create built-in accountability, making it more likely that goals move from imagination to action. Most importantly, the process can be surprisingly fun. There is a playful quality to exploring possibilities, comparing ideas, and encouraging one another's dreams. In many ways, it becomes a real-life version of *A Game of Life*—except in this game, everyone has the opportunity to win, provided they choose to play.

Kickstart Worksheet #1: The Five Minute Brain Dump

Set a timer for five minutes. Do not overthink. Write quickly. Your goal is not accuracy or perfection—your goal is simply to allow your brain to begin exploring.

Write down:

- Things I have always wanted to try:

- Places I have always wanted to visit:

- Skills I wish I knew:

- Experiences I sometimes think about but keep postponing:

- Things I regret not doing yet:

"You can't use up creativity. The more you use, the more you have."

— Maya Angelou

Kickstart Worksheet #2: The “Someday” Exercise

Fill in the blanks as quickly as possible. Remember this exercise is about you and your life goals and dreams.

Someday I want to:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____

Now circle:

- ☐ The easiest
- ☐ The most exciting
- ☐ The most meaningful
- ☐ The one that scares you slightly
- ☐ The one you want to share with someone special.

"Your time is limited, so don't waste it living someone else's life."

— Steve Jobs

Kickstart Worksheet #3: Future Self Exercise

Imagine yourself ten years from now. What experiences would future-you be thankful you started today?

➤ Future me would thank me for:

➤ What would future-you regret continuing to postpone?

➤ What do you want your future legacy to look like?

"What you are is what you have been. What you'll be is what you do now."

— Buddha

Kickstart Worksheet #4: Finding Your Missing Categories

Place a check mark next to areas receiving enough attention in your current life.

- ☐ Travel / Exploration
- ☐ Mindfulness / Spirituality
- ☐ Contribution / Helping Others / Volunteerism
- ☐ Adventure / Risk
- ☐ Learning / Achievement
- ☐ Relationships / Connection
- ☐ Creativity
- ☐ Health / Physical Experiences
- ☐ Fun / Playfulness / Hobbies
- ☐ Art / Music
- ☐ New Experiences / Novelty / Breaking Routine
- ☐ Material Items / Purchases

Which categories need more attention?

"Knowing yourself is the beginning of all wisdom."

— Aristotle

Kickstart Worksheet #5: Build Your First Micro Goal

Large goals often fail because the brain perceives them as expensive, uncertain, or overwhelming. Here, we want you to think of something you can begin right away.

Choose ONE item.

My Goal: _____

Smallest Possible First Step: _____

Can I complete this within:

☐ 5 Minutes

☐ 30 Minutes

☐ One Day

When will I do this?

Date: _____

Time: _____

What will make success easier? _____

How will it feel to begin this? _____

☐ Check when completed: Date _____ Time _____

How did it feel to complete this? _____

"The journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step."
— Lao Tzu

Kickstart Worksheet #6: Your First Bucket List Ideas

Write down five items only. Not fifty. Not one hundred. These Can be things you've always wanted to do, or maybe some new ideas!

Just five.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Now rank them:

Most Exciting: # _____

Most Realistic: # _____

Most Meaningful: # _____

Which one likely to happen first? # _____

Which one would be best to do with others? # _____

Final Reflection

After completing these exercises:

What surprised you? _____

What excited you? _____

What small step(s) can happen within the next seven days? _____

"The indispensable first step to getting the things you want out of life is this: Decide what you want."

— Ben Stein

Worksheet #7: Building Your Bucket List Categories

Creating bucket list categories before creating specific goals may help your brain organize what truly matters to you rather than simply generating random ideas or copying someone else's bucket list. Read through the required categories first. Then create categories 4–8 based upon what feels important, meaningful, exciting, or missing from your own life.

Recommended Categories

1. Travel & Exploration
2. Mindfulness / Presence
3. Giving Back / Philanthropy / Volunteerism

Now create 5 more categories (#4–#8) of your own. Just 5 for now. Not 50.

4.

5.

6.

7.

8.

Reflection

Which category feels most important right now?

Which category surprised you by appearing on your list?

Which category has received the least attention in your life recently?

Your Bucket List Journal/Worksheets: Finding a System That Works For You

Many people become stuck before they even begin because they assume there must be a perfect way to create a bucket list. In reality, there is no single system that works for everyone because brains, personalities, motivations, and lifestyles differ tremendously from person to person. The purpose of this worksheet is not to teach the “correct” way to build a bucket list; it is



simply to provide a structured place to begin.

The most important part is not whether your list is beautiful, organized, color-coded, handwritten, or digital. The most important part is that your ideas, goals, experiences, and progress exist somewhere outside of your head where they can grow, evolve, and be revisited over time.

Think of your bucket list less like a static document and more like a living journal of experiences, possibilities, and personal growth. Some people prefer structured worksheets like this one because organization helps them stay focused. Others may prefer blank journals or notebooks that allow greater creativity and flexibility. Some individuals enjoy digital systems such as spreadsheets, note-taking apps, shared documents, or dedicated goal-tracking applications because they are easier to update and carry with them. More visually oriented people may enjoy creating vision boards, travel maps, photo journals, or scrapbook-style systems. Highly achievement-oriented individuals sometimes prefer checklists and timelines, while reflective personalities may prefer narrative journaling with stories, lessons learned, and observations. The format itself matters far less than consistency.

Ultimately, your bucket list system should feel easy enough that you will continue using it. Whether you use these worksheets repeatedly, purchase a dedicated journal, create a digital file, use sticky notes on a wall, or carry a small notebook with you throughout the day, the goal remains the same: create a system that allows your brain to capture ideas, plan experiences, track progress, and remind yourself that life is still unfolding. Movement matters more than perfection, and starting matters more than waiting for the perfect system.

My Bucket List Worksheet (Basic Style)

Bucket List Category: _____

Goal 1: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Goal 2: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Goal 3: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Goal 4: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Goal 5: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Goal 6: _____

☐ Thinking About It ☐ Planned ☐ Started ☐ Completed

Thoughts: _____

Before We End, Make Sure You Start

If this Starter Kit accomplished one thing, I hope it helped create movement. Perhaps it encouraged you to think differently about what you want from life. Perhaps it reminded you of experiences you have postponed, dreams that became buried beneath responsibilities, or parts of yourself that simply needed permission to re-emerge. Most importantly, I hope it reminded you that meaningful change rarely begins with giant leaps; it usually begins with small moments of curiosity, reflection, and action.

The concepts introduced throughout this Starter Kit and explored in much greater depth in the main book and workbook were built around a simple but powerful idea: the brain changes in response to how we live. Novelty, learning, purpose, relationships, intentionality, exploration, gratitude, and meaningful experiences do not simply make life feel fuller; they provide important signals that encourage the brain to remain engaged, adaptable, and healthy. While no single system guarantees happiness or perfect mental health, creating a life filled with meaningful experiences may help support emotional well-being, cognitive resilience, psychological flexibility, and overall quality of life.

Most importantly, remember that your bucket list is not really a list at all. It is a living system designed to help pull you forward through life. It is your reminder that growth remains possible, curiosity remains valuable, and meaningful experiences still await you. Whether your first step is large or small, exciting or uncomfortable, expensive or completely free, what matters most is that you continue moving.

If you would like to continue exploring these concepts, visit BucketListDoctor.com—a unique website dedicated to the science and practice of bucket listing featuring articles, videos, resources, and ideas created by Dr. Jeffrey DeSarbo, a neuropsychiatrist, experienced bucket lister, and lifelong student of how the brain can help us live fuller and more meaningful lives.

"The future depends on what you do today."

— Mahatma Gandhi

Visit our website today!

For more insights, tips and advice, Dr. Desarbo's articles on bucket listing, the brain and neuroscience, videos and media, and inspiration on living a bucket list life, visit:

BucketListDoctor.com

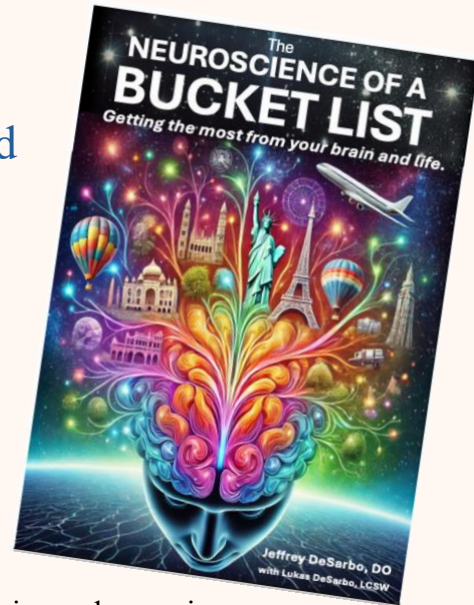


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About Our Books

The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life

*by Jeffrey R. DeSarbo, D.O.
with Lukas DeSarbo, L.C.S.W.*



The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life is more than a book about creating lists of dreams and adventures—it is an invitation to rethink what it truly means to live fully.

Blending cutting-edge neuroscience with practical strategies and engaging storytelling, this book explores how goal setting, novelty, purpose, and meaningful experiences shape not only the quality of life but also the structure and function of the brain itself. A bucket list is far more than a collection of experiences waiting to be checked off. It can become a powerful framework for reshaping how life is approached, how meaning is created, and how the brain continues to grow, adapt, and thrive. Through both science and storytelling, readers are introduced to the fascinating ways meaningful goals influence motivation, resilience, creativity, happiness, and psychological well-being.

At its core, this book is about intentional living. It explores how aligning aspirations with personal values can create deeper fulfillment while offering practical guidance for identifying what truly matters, overcoming fear and self-doubt, maintaining motivation through setbacks, and learning to appreciate both the destination and the journey itself. Throughout the book, emphasis is placed not only on achievement but also on reflection, gratitude, and the importance of celebrating progress along the way.

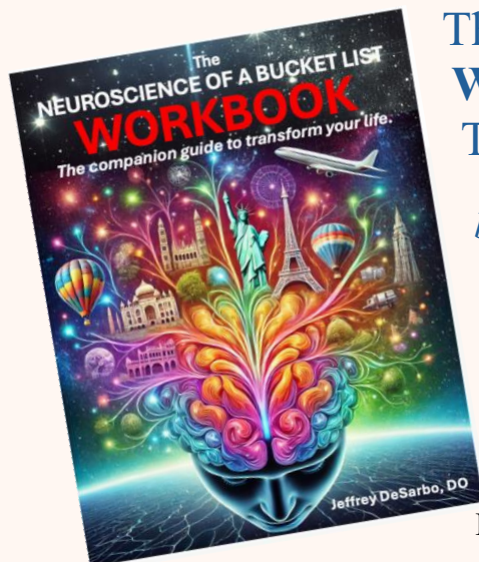
The science behind motivation and human behavior serves as the foundation for this journey. Topics such as dopamine and reward processing, neuroplasticity, visualization, cognitive flexibility, and brain network functioning are translated into accessible concepts that connect directly to everyday life. Readers are introduced to the neuroscience underlying purpose,

novelty, learning, social connection, adventure, and personal growth while gaining insight into how bucket-list living may influence brain aging, cognitive resilience, and psychological health.

What distinguishes *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List* is its narrative approach. Scientific concepts are woven together with personal stories and real-world examples of individuals who transformed their lives through intentional goal setting and meaningful experiences. These stories illustrate how ordinary people create extraordinary change—not simply through achievement, but through the decision to actively engage with life itself.

To move beyond inspiration and into action, the book includes a practical workbook section to help readers create a structured, personalized bucket list. Step-by-step guidance is provided for identifying meaningful goals, breaking them into achievable steps, developing sustainable habits, and building a life aligned with personal values and aspirations. To stimulate creativity and exploration, the book also includes over 50 categories and more than 650 bucket-list ideas designed to spark curiosity and encourage new possibilities.

Ultimately, this book offers more than a collection of ideas—it provides a framework for building a life rich in purpose, novelty, connection, and growth while harnessing the remarkable capacity of the human brain to continually adapt, evolve, and thrive.



The Neuroscience of a Bucket List Workbook: The Companion Guide to Transform Your Life

by Jeffrey R. Desarbo, D.O.

The Neuroscience of a Bucket List Workbook: The Companion Guide to Transform Your Life is the official hands-on companion to the groundbreaking book, *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life*. Designed as more than simply a collection of

exercises, this workbook serves as a practical extension of the original concepts, transforming inspiration into meaningful action through custom-designed activities, planning tools, reflective prompts, and neuroscience-informed worksheets.

Rooted in the idea that intentional living can reshape the brain for growth, resilience, wellness, and longevity, this workbook moves beyond simple bucket-list brainstorming and into the process of creating a life filled with purpose and meaningful experiences. Whether beginning a first bucket list, overcoming personal barriers, or expanding existing goals into something greater, this workbook provides structured guidance while meeting readers wherever they are in their journey.

Inside, readers will discover expanded bucket-list categories, creative prompts, and experiential ideas designed for every stage of life. Step-by-step planning strategies help transform aspirations into realistic, achievable goals, while reflective exercises uncover deeper personal values and align life choices with principles of neuroscience and behavioral change. Guided prompts help clarify intention, strengthen motivation, overcome psychological obstacles, and create momentum toward meaningful action.

Throughout the workbook, practical tools are designed to strengthen many of the brain systems involved in motivation, learning, resilience, memory, adaptability, and long-term psychological well-being through experiential living and purposeful engagement with the world. Perfect for individuals seeking both structure and flexibility, this workbook builds upon the foundation introduced in *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List* while providing a personalized framework for creating a richer, more intentional life. Regardless of age, background, or socioeconomic status, readers are encouraged to design experiences that nourish the brain while enriching everyday life.

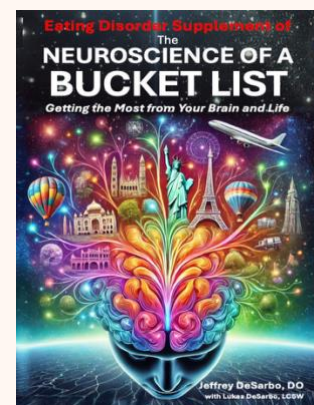
This is not simply a workbook for dreaming; it is a workbook for doing. Whether approaching bucket listing for the first time or searching for a fresh perspective after years of adventure, this guide provides the tools to build a life defined by gratitude, resilience, purpose, novelty, and meaningful experiences.

The Eating Disorder Supplement of The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life

by Jeffrey R. DeSarbo, D.O.
with Lukas DeSarbo, L.C.S.W.

The Eating Disorder Supplement to The Neuroscience of a Bucket List is an advanced companion book that applies modern

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neuroscience, psychology, and lived clinical experience to help readers understand eating disorders in a completely new way. Written by neuropsychiatrist and eating disorder specialist Dr. Jeffrey DeSarbo, with, Lukas DeSarbo, LCSW, this book explores what is happening inside the brain and nervous system during eating disorders while offering practical strategies designed to support recovery through purpose, novelty, meaning, and experiential living.

Drawing on the principles from *The Neuroscience of a Bucket List: Getting the Most from Your Brain and Life*, this supplement introduces a novel therapeutic framework that helps individuals move beyond merely reducing symptoms to actively rebuild lives worth living. Through neuroscience-informed exercises, real-world case examples, recovery strategies, and bucket list interventions specifically adapted for eating disorders, readers will learn how intentional experiences, novelty, purpose, social connection, and meaningful goals can help reshape neural pathways and promote recovery.

In this second edition, the powerful new component of *Demystification Therapy* is introduced. This section is designed to help clinicians and patients alike understand the neuroscience behind eating disorders in a way that is both accessible and actionable. Although the neuroscience material is advanced, it is intentionally simplified to highlight a critical truth that is too often overlooked: an eating disorder is fundamentally a neurobiologically based condition.

Designed for clinicians, therapists, educators, and anyone seeking a deeper understanding of eating disorders, this book transforms complex neuroscience into accessible explanations, offering hope that recovery is not simply about eating differently; it is about helping the brain learn to live differently.

Books Available Through

www.Amazon.com

www.BookBaby.com



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ABOUT THE AUTHORS



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Dr. Jeffrey DeSarbo is a neuropsychiatrist in Garden City, Long Island, New York who specializes in the treatment of eating disorders and general psychiatric conditions with a focus on the neurobiological underpinnings of mental health and cognitive conditions. He has embraced a bucket list philosophy over the last 30 years of his life.



Lukas S. DeSarbo, LCSW, Psychotherapist

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